After Virtual Reality Exhibition

15-21 October 2026

Registrations and more info at:
https://s.cdn.uib.no/aftervirtualreality
https://www.tickettailor.com/events/xdn

The Grand Hotel Bald Cockatoo

(Immersive Installation | 2026)
Created by Roderick Coover, Caitlin Fisher and Scott Rettberg

Installation with five channel video and two channel audio

Platforms used: Runway, Seedance 2.0, Lumina Dream Machine, Adobe Premier, Adobe Audition, ChatGPT Image, Adobe Firefly, Claude (coding), ElevenLabs, Python, Carpentry.

The Grand Hotel Bald Cockatoo is an immersive installation, the second work in the Visitations: The Grand Hotels (of Joseph Cornell) series. Based on perhaps the most absurd of Robert Coover's sketches from his book The Grand Hotels (of Joseph Cornell), this hotel is a hotel of dreams, in which the hotel manager is a fortunetelling cockatoo. The audience enters a large installation in the form of a bird's nest. Embedded in the walls of the nest are four large screens, where short dream narratives recombine. The authors wrote the dream narratives in an adapted exquisite-corpse fashion, using AI text-to-video generation as a prompt. Voices based on modernist authors, tracked separately from the videos, narrate the stories. At the back of the nest is the fortune-teller and an interactive fortune-telling device. Guests can press a button to generate a fortune of their own, which is printed for them to take home.

Bio:

Roderick Coover is a filmmaker, digital artist, and professor of Film and Media Arts at Temple University in Philadelphia. A pioneer of interactive cinema and immersive storytelling, he combines documentary research, experimental film, and digital technologies to explore environmental change, cultural experience, and the possibilities of narrative. His works include *Unknown Territories*, *Toxi•City: A Climate Change Narrative*, and the collaborative virtual reality installation *Hearts and Minds: The Interrogations Project*. His projects have been exhibited internationally, including at the Venice Biennale, SIGGRAPH, and the Bibliothèque nationale de France. He edited *The Digital Imaginary: Literature and Cinema of the Database* and coedited *Switching Codes*. Coover holds a doctorate from the University of Chicago and received Fulbright, Mellon, and Whiting fellowships and awards. He is collaborating with Caitlin Fisher and Scott Rettberg on the *Visitations: The Grand Hotels (of Joseph Cornell)* series of immersive narratives.

Bio

Caitlin Fischer is an award-winning digital storyteller and poet, working mostly in XR. She directs the art+ science Immersive Storytelling Lab and the Augmented Reality Lab at York University in Toronto. At York she is also Chair and a Full Professor in the Department of Film and Media Arts. A co-founder of York's Future Cinema Lab and former Fulbright and Canada Research Chair, Caitlin has funded research projects in the areas of AI storytelling, co-creation between settler and indigenous artists in VR environments and is bringing the power of storytelling to the global health crisis of antimicrobial resistance through a new XR Museum project. She is immediate past President of the Electronic Literature Organization and is also a Prof. II at the University of Bergen, working with the Centre for Digital Narrative.

Bio:

Scott Rettberg is director of the Center for Digital Narrative (CDN), a Norwegian Centre of Research Excellence, and professor of digital culture at the University of Bergen. A writer, artist, and scholar, he explores how computational technologies transform storytelling, authorship, and creative practice. He cofounded the Electronic Literature Organization and served as its first executive director. His book Electronic Literature received the 2019 N. Katherine Hayles Award for Criticism of Electronic Literature. His collaborative works include The Unknown, Implementation, and Hearts and Minds: The Interrogations Project, winner of the 2016 Robert Coover Award. Rettberg leads the Extending Digital Narrative project, investigating emerging narrative forms through artistic experimentation with artificial intelligence, games, and extended reality. He is collaborating with Roderick Coover and Caitlin Fisher on the Visitations: The Grand Hotels (of Joseph Cornell) series of immersive narratives.

Website: https://retts.net/grandhotels/
Contact info: Scott.Rettberg@uib.no

Finding Frida

(Immersive Installation / Immersive video | 2026)
Created by Hilde K. Kjøs (Director & Story Design), Cecilie Levy (Scriptwriter & Original Idea) and Bjørn-Morten Nerland (Producer)

Platforms used: Blender, 3ds Max, Mistika, DaVinci Resolve, Photoshop, RealityCapture, Pro Tools

In a "real unreality" VR space, a miniature Art Nouveau villa appears before expanding to full scale. Past and present weave together as we step into the world of Frida Hansen – once an internationally acclaimed textile artist, now largely forgotten. Guided by her great-great-granddaughter Cecilie, we explore a lush garden where archival photographs, a gramophone and woven artworks become portals into Frida's life. As bankruptcy and profound personal grief descend, the vibrant garden withers into darkness. From this desolation emerge four enigmatic female figures, foreshadowing the work Semper Vadentes and the beginning of Frida's artistic awakening. Across a century, Frida and Cecilie's lives intertwine. Through art, hardship is transformed into enduring beauty – a testament to how the role models we uncover continue to inspire and shape who we become.

Registrations at: https://www.tickettailor.com/events/xdn/2454489

Director's biography

Hilde K. Kjøs is an award-winning filmmaker and photographer working across documentary, photography and immersive media. Her artistic practice explores place, memory and human presence. With a cinematic approach grounded in observation and visual subtext, Kjøs creates intimate encounters that invite audiences into complex human narratives. Her acclaimed documentaries *Harvesting the Wasteland (Lykkens grøde)* and *Solace* (Sju kammers) have screened internationally and won multiple awards. In September 2026, her VR debut *Finding Frida* premiered at the 83rd Venice International Film Festival, Venice Immersive.

Screenwriters' biography

Cecilie Levy is an independent screenwriter and lecturer at the University of Amsterdam, Department of Media Studies. In 2023 she completed a PhD in Artistic Research at the Norwegian Film School with her project *Light From Aside: A Screenwriter's Perspective in Virtual Reality*. Works include shorts, children's series, films for television and feature film-screened internationally, on television and festivals. Levy has won several awards, incl. the Prix Jeunesse (Prix Europa), the Lucas Award and a nomination for an International Emmy® Kids Awards. Part of the jury Digital Culture at the Dutch Film Festival in Utrecht, 2025.

Producers' biography

Bjørn-Morten Nerland is an XR producer and cinematographer based in Oslo, Norway, with more than 15 years of experience creating immersive experiences. He is the founder of RippleX Studios, an immersive production company specialising in virtual reality, spatial storytelling and interactive experiences. His work spans exhibitions, documentaries, commercial productions, music videos and immersive installations, combining cinematic storytelling with emerging technologies. He holds a Bachelor's degree in Media Technology from Lillehammer University College and has received multiple Gullruten (Norwegian Emmy) nominations, including for Innovation of the Year. His work has also been recognised as an Official Honoree at the Webby Awards for Best Use of Interactive Video, and he received the Best VR Film award at the VRINN Awards 2024.

His current work focuses on immersive documentary storytelling at the intersection of culture, heritage and emerging technologies.

Glasslike Fabric

(Augmented Reality / Interactive Digital Literature | 2026)
Created by Jason Nelson

Platforms used: OpenCV.js

Glasslike Fabric is an interactive narrative where the reader scans the world, anything, everywhere, and generates strange stories about things capture by their phone's camera. The

viewer points at a room, street, object or landscape and presses Scan. The work captures a still image, finds shapes within it and outlines selected regions. Red and grey lines, arrows, labels and fragments of equations connect the shapes.

The work uses OpenCV.js to detect edges and colour boundaries, identify contours and select prominent shapes. Tapping an outlined shape opens a short fictional incident report, assembled from prewritten phrases using a far too complex generative story engine. The shape's type determines which opening phrases are available, while its size and complexity also affect the brief stories.

These are generated stories of places where neighbouring dimensions overlapped, allowing materials and objects to intermingle and impact their respective worlds. Trajectories change direction, glass retains an image, a wall becomes fabric.

With a near infinite number of stories, the work builds new worlds with every new snapshot of what's around you, ordinary surroundings become imagined incidents, diagrams measure the evidential rate.

Bio:

Jason Nelson is a digital poet and artist, combining poetry, narrative, mages, sound, movement and interaction in digital writing and games. He grew up in Oklahoma City and became a digital writer in Australia. He Professes all sorts of magic things at the University of Bergen and is a principal investigator in the Center for Digital Narrative. His works have won 14 awards and prizes, including a Webby, Queensland Premiere's Literary prize, and the ELO Maverick Award among others.

Website: https://dpoetry.com
Contact info: Jason.nelson@uib.no

The Land of Crystals

(Video | 2026)
Created by Eamon O'Kane

Platforms used:

The Land of Crystals creates a moving panorama from archival photographs and historical images of Edvard Munch's demolished house and studios at Ekely in Oslo. Through the manipulation and sequencing of these still images, the film reconstructs a place that no longer exists, creating a virtual passage through Munch's working environment and the landscape that surrounded it.

The film's voice-over is drawn from Munch's writings in *The Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil*, a portfolio of texts and images compiled at Ekely in 1915–16. Several of the archival photographs show Munch in his Winter Studio, creating a direct connection between the written voice heard in the film and the physical spaces in which these texts were conceived.

The Norwegian texts are spoken by an AI-generated voice. This introduces an intentional tension between historical memory and contemporary technology. Munch recorded his voice onto wax cylinders during his lifetime, but none of these recordings have survived, and there is no known surviving recording that allows us to hear what his voice sounded like. The voice in *The Land of Crystals* is therefore neither an attempt to reproduce Munch's actual voice nor a historical reconstruction. Instead, it occupies the space between absence and imagination: a technologically generated voice giving sound to words whose author's own voice has been irretrievably lost.

The title is taken from Munch's writings, in which he refers to a "Land of Crystals." For O'Kane, the phrase becomes both a poetic image and a conceptual framework for thinking about memory, geological time, transformation, and the archive. The film considers how technology can reactivate fragments of the past while simultaneously reminding us of what can never be recovered.

Bio:

Eamon O'Kane (b. 1974, Belfast) is an Irish artist and Professor of Visual Art at the University of Bergen, Norway. Working across painting, drawing, photography, sculpture, installation and AI-generated imagery, his practice explores the relationships between memory, architecture, ecology and changing technologies. His work frequently takes modernist architecture, domestic spaces, artist studios and landscapes as sites through which histories and temporalities can be examined.

O'Kane's long-term projects include *Greenhouse Archive*, a decade-long documentation and artistic investigation of a former plant nursery in Denmark, and *The School of Generational Storytelling*, developed through collaborations with care homes and communities in Ireland. His research also encompasses climate narratives, posthumanism, and the role of AI within contemporary artistic practice. He has exhibited internationally through solo and group exhibitions, publications, and research projects. O'Kane is a member of the leader group of the Centre for Digital Narrative at the University of Bergen.

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Bybanen Slop Surfer

(VR Game / VR Installation | 2026)
Created by Colin Robinson

Byybanen Slop Surfer is a playable descent into AI slop: a version of Bergen flattened, exaggerated and reassembled through the visual language of algorithmically generated culture.

The work takes a recognizable city and subjects it to the same processes increasingly applied to images, writing, music and online culture: simplification, repetition, imitation and endless recombination.

Bergen becomes simultaneously familiar and synthetic — a cheerful approximation of itself.

Bio:

Colin Robinson is a technical artist and engineer interested in experimental forms of interaction and play. His works span 3D art, game design, electronics, fabrication, and software, with a particular interest in challenging established design conventions, finding questionable uses for new technologies, and making people smile.

The Fishbowl Leaks

(Augmented Reality / Work in Progress | 2026)
Created by Jakob Kusnick

The Fishbowl Leaks transform(s) the exhibition into a porous virtual aquarium…

Visitors encounter fragments of the surrounding works as marine life and unstable species through a browser-based augmented reality layer. Each encounter alters a personal creature, shaped by the visitor's movement through the exhibition, transforming it into a generative story. The aquarium acts as both environment and metaphor. It displays containment but also resembles a collective, developing system. On a shared screen, the aquarium begins in a state of order: partitioned and classified. As visitors contribute their creatures, this order gradually breaks down. Texts detach, species break free, the tank falls apart, and memory is leaking, releasing the creatures into open waters…

The Fishbowl Leaks imagine(s) a living narrative ecosystem. The single artworks start in fixed categories and grow together into a symbiotic, participatory collective, by the help of exhibition visitors. The result sits between exhibition guide, generative story system, and shared hallucination in a container. What might evolve when that container starts to leak?

Bio:

Jakob Kusnick is a LEAD AI postdoctoral fellow at the Center for Digital Narrative in the Department of Linguistic, Literary and Aesthetic Studies at the University of Bergen. He leads Narrative Nubs, a project in collaboration with Nick Montfort at MIT that explores AI story generators and develops miniature versions of them as a platform for research, teaching, and artistic practice. His research investigates how interactive visualizations can make these complex systems understandable and usable, for example, through glyph-based summaries for comparing AI story systems and interfaces for tracing generation processes and analyzing large collections of outputs. Jakob received his PhD in Computer Science in 2024 from the University of Southern Denmark in Odense, where his dissertation focused on visualization-based storytelling for digital humanities. He then continued there as a postdoctoral researcher, with work spanning tangible and intangible cultural heritage, musicology, history, sustainability, and the life sciences.

Website: kusnick.com

Contact info: jakob@kusnick.com

Between Page and Screen

(Augmented Reality / Interactive Digital Literature | 2009)
Created by Amaranth Borsuk and Brad Bouse

An unlikely marriage of print and digital, *Between Page and Screen* chronicles a love affair between two characters, P and S.
The book has no words, only inscrutable black and white geometric patterns that, when coupled with a webcam, conjure the written word. Reflected on screen, the reader sees him or herself with open book in hand, language springing alive and shape-shifting with each turn of the page. The story unfolds through a playful and cryptic exchange of letters between P and S as they struggle to define their relationship. Rich with innuendo, anagrams, etymological and sonic affinities between words, *Between Page and Screen* revels in language and the act of reading.

Bio:

Amaranth Borsuk is the author of *Pomegranate Eater* (Kore Press, 2016), a collection of poems; *As We Know* (Subito, 2014), a book-length erasure collaboration with Andy Fitch; *Handiwork* (Slope Editions, 2012), selected by Paul Hoover for the 2011 Slope Editions Book Prize; and *Tonal Saw* (The Song Cave, 2010), a chapbook. *Abra* (1913 Press, 2016), a book of mutating poems created with Kate Durbin, received an NEA-sponsored Expanded Artists' Books grant from the Center for Book and Paper Arts at Columbia College Chicago and was recently released as a limited-edition book with a free iPad / iPhone app created by Ian Hatcher." Borsuk's other digital collaborations include *The Deletionist* , an erasure bookmarklet created with Nick Montfort and Jesper Juul; and *Whispering Galleries* , a site-specific LeapMotion interactive textwork for the New Haven Free Public Library. Borsuk received her Ph.D. in Literature and Creative Writing at the University of Southern California and served as a Mellon Postdoctoral Fellow in the Humanities at MIT before joining the faculty of the University of Washington, Bothell, where she is currently an Assistant Professor in the School of Interdisciplinary Arts and Sciences.

Brad Bouse is a developer whose work focuses on the intersection of art and technology. He is the co-founder of Lightboard. He frequently presents about art and code, including this presentation about the Usefulness of Uselessness at JSConf.EU in Berlin.

Website: https://www.betweenpageandscreen.com
Contact info: hello@betweenpageandscreen.com.

REALIDAD MITIGADA

(Augmented Reality / Interactive Digital Literature | 2022)
Created by Tina Escaja

Realidad Mitigada (Mitigated Reality) is an AR/Extended Reality App created for the project and hybrid book *Realidad Mitigada*, a book that collects poems and digital "artefacts" by Tina Escaja (aka Alm@ Pérez). Many of Escaja's poems and digital works reflects upon issues of

social justice, such as domestic violence (Luna Morada/Black Moon) and informatics control (Bar Codes), which makes this book particularly relevant given its potential subversion of traditional technologies that have served to legitimate oppression, such as the printing press. *Realidad mitigada / Mitigated Reality* is an innovative work created by four professionals in the digital arts. The AR app for the project allows the reader to have an "extended reality" experience that will provide a unique and groundbreaking involvement. The series of stickers located at the end of the book expands the "Virus and the Sea" segment of the book to the community by inviting the reader to place them in random locations, in the way that the QR codes for Escaja's COVID-19 project have already been posted in cities around the world to collect testimonies about our experiences during the pandemic.

Bio:

Tina Escaja (also known as Alm@ Pérez) is a Spanish-American poet, writer, feminist scholar, and digital artist. She is a Distinguished Professor of Spanish and Gender Studies at the University of Vermont, where her research explores gender, technology, and contemporary Spanish and Latin American literature. Considered a pioneer of electronic literature in Spanish, her interdisciplinary practice combines poetry, digital media, robotics, augmented reality, and multimedia installations to challenge conventional literary forms and explore the intersections of technology, identity, and social justice. Her digital works have been exhibited internationally in museums and galleries. Her literary awards include the Dulce María Loynaz International Poetry Prize for *Caída libre* (2004) and the Campoy-Ada Prize for young adult poetry (2017).

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XDN [Work-in-Progress]

Historically Yours

(Interactive Installation / Work in progress | 2026)
Created by Lina Ruth Harder

Historically Yours is an interactive podcast broadcasting from the Underworld. This work in progress gives visitors a direct line to Cleo, Toinette and Henri, three fictional hosts loosely inspired by Cleopatra, Queen Marie Antoinette and astronomer Henrietta Swan Leavitt.

In the installation, visitors listen through headphones and send the hosts a question, a grievance or whatever is keeping them awake. Artificial intelligence transforms each contribution into a new conversation, performed through three synthetic voices. A live transcript accompanies the discussion, while illuminated sculptural heads reveal who has the microphone.

The hosts are not digital reconstructions of historical people. They are deliberately unreliable approximations assembled from historical fragments, popular myths and cultural stereotypes. Their appearances, both on screen and as 3D printed sculptures, reflect the familiar visual clichés through which historical women are recognised. Their voices are equally speculative. We do not

know what these women sounded like, yet synthetic speech gives each host the persuasive impression of an individual personality.

The work draws on the *Dialogues of the Dead*, a satirical tradition in which historical figures meet in the afterlife to gossip, argue and judge the living. Here, it becomes a feminist podcast in which women who have been celebrated, blamed, romanticised or overlooked discuss the present from the Underworld.

Part podcast, part séance and part critique of synthetic authority, *Historically Yours* asks who gets to represent the past and why a convincing face and voice can be so easy to believe.

Bio:

Lina Ruth Harder is a PhD Fellow at the Center for Digital Narrative at the University of Bergen. Her practice based research explores generative AI, historical simulation and interactive narrative. Drawing on her background in museums and digital communication, she creates AI driven works about history, memory and encounters between humans and machines. She coined the term *histobots* for conversational agents that simulate people from the past. Through critical and playful experiments with emerging technologies, her work examines how historical personalities are constructed, whose stories are remembered and how artificial intelligence reshapes our relationship with the past.

Website: www.lina.berlin
Contact info: hello@betweenpageandscreen.com.

YOUR UPDATE HAS FAILED

(WEBXR / Interactive Browser / Work in progress | 2026)
Created by Sérgio Galvão Roxo

YOUR UPDATE HAS FAILED is an interactive browser and WebXR experience tracing the digital evolution of SOGICE—sexual orientation and gender identity change efforts. These interventions seek to change or suppress LGBTQIA+ people's sexual orientation, gender identity, or expression.

A computer anchors the narrative as three composite lives unfold across 1997, 2003, 2016, and 2026—each in a room shaped by its era. SOGICE's forms evolve: printed questionnaires become software, then wellness platforms, moderation tools, and, eventually, AI-driven systems that classify and collect data. Blending documented practices with imagined scenes, the work reveals SOGICE not as a single event, but as a digital ecosystem spanning "ex-gay" testimonies, promotional videos, exercises, prayers, and data systems. Language shifts toward care and progress, but the underlying pressure to conform remains.

With each update, the system appears new; with each restart, it enters another era; and with every glitch, its limits are exposed. Visitors navigate the story through a headset, desktop, or phone—clicking, reading, and turning to explore the changing rooms. A dossier accompanies the work,

linking sources with the narrative. Through its many transformations, SOGICE's apparatus adapts and renews its promise of correction, but its failure endures: queer life persists.

Bio:

Sérgio Galvão Roxo (1990, Portugal) is an artist, researcher, and LGBTQIA+ social intervention specialist. He is currently a PhD Research Fellow at the University of Bergen, exploring audiovisual storytelling and immersive media as tools for awareness, belonging, activism, and education.

His work *Her Name Was Gisberta* (2023), an immersive documentary, has been showcased at international festivals, including SXSW, DOK Leipzig, and Ji.hlava IDFF. The project received the AIXR Inclusivity XR Grant (2024) and was nominated for the AIXR Social Impact Award (2024). It also won the National Grand Prix at FEST — New Directors | New Films Festival (2024).

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From Ingrid to Bergen

(Interactive Documentary | 2026)
Created by Pedro Velho

Technology is reshaping our relationships and communication with the dead, using digital traces of the data they leave behind. Decades before these technologies emerged, I was already doing something similar.
From Ingrid to Bergen is an interactive documentary about grief, memory, theatre, and the technologies we use to maintain relationships with what is no longer there. Moving across nineteen years, the project brings together personal archives, photographs, paintings, videos, and texts from different phases of my experience of loss. An idea of a grandmother, a promise, ghosts, forests, neurodivergence, theatre, and Ingrid Bergman form a shifting map through memory and reconstruction, tracing not only the loss of a person, but also the loss of what I once imagined becoming.

Bio:

Pedro Queirós Pinto, artistically known as Pedro Velho, is a researcher, mediator, educator, and creative based in Bergen, Norway. He is currently a Research Assistant in the Extending Digital Narrative (XDN) group at the Center for Digital Narrative (CDN), University of Bergen, where he focuses on digital narratives and creative practices.

His work spans mediation, narrative, non-fiction, and performance, drawing on intermedial and socially engaged approaches to explore how creative practice shapes the conditions for meaningful encounters among people, stories, and communities.

Website: https://pedro-velho.com/
Contact info: Pedro.Pinto@uib.no

Performances – IGNORE THIS

19/10 *| Cinemateket*

17:00-18:30 (Requires sign-up)

Registration at: https://www.tickettailor.com/events/xdn/2454481

Latent Laughing Medusa

(Performance | 2026)
Created by Judd Morrissey

"Wherever she loves, all the old concepts of management are left behind"
-Helene Cixous, The Laugh of Medusa (in translation)

As machines increasingly generate our language, what remains irreducibly human—if not the body and its unspeakable excess? *Latent Laughing Medusa* is a live performance that explores what emerges when language is no longer supervised by a single voice, human or machine. Working at the intersection of generative AI, somatic writing, and collective participation, the piece asks how computational systems might be redirected away from totalization and toward multiplicity, breath, and embodied overflow.

The project takes inspiration from Hélène Cixous' 1975 essay The Laugh of the Medusa, written the year of my birth. While Cixous' call was addressed explicitly to women writing from historically silenced bodies, this work approaches her text from a queer, gender-expansive position: not as inheritance, but as listening across time. If Cixous urged women to "write the body," this performance asks what body-writing might look like in the age of large language models.

A composed text, part meditation on memory, signification, gender, and the experience of undergoing a ketamine therapy trial, will serve as the performance's initial spine. As the event unfolds, this text gradually unwrites and recomposes itself through the friction between vocal utterance, gesture, generative AI outputs, and live audience participation. Linear semantic language loosens into spatialized, sonic, and affective clusterings drawn from the shared field of performer, participants, and machine.

Participants will be invited into structured, often nonverbal interventions—breath, laughter, murmured phonemes—creating a distributed chorus. These inputs will be processed in real time, feeding an evolving computational system that recombines language without stabilizing it into a single authoritative meaning. Through green-screen wearables and body-mapped visual projection, emerging text and image will be literally inscribed into and across the performer's body, rendering visible a hybrid "latent space" of somatic and synthetic processes.

Framed as a poetic ritual, the performance moves between destabilization and release. It inhabits the risks of unsupervised systems, where coherence fractures and authority dissolves, while exploring whether such destabilization can open into collective and erotic forms of expression. The event concludes by returning to its opening text, now altered by the shared encounter, suggesting that unsupervised clustering may generate new proximities without resolving into certainty.

At a moment marked by the consolidation of algorithmic language, the regulation of gendered bodies, and the contraction of institutions, **Latent Laughing Medusa** proposes a temporary, many-voiced zone of embodied inscription, where language does not conclude but vibrates.

The It-ernal Now

(Performance Lecture | 2026)

Created by David Jhave Johnston

A performative lecture on AI consciousness, proposing tentative methods for relaxing into the virtuality of reality as it decomposes into ambiguity & an exploration of how to play peacefully through an A.I. apocalypse.

When a human looks at an AI looking back who or what is looking at who or what?
Or is there just embodied-looking and computer-looking?

What does it mean to be real?
What does it mean to be you?
What does it mean to be me?
What does it mean to be us?
What does it mean to be?

Reality may be Virtual Reality.

XR Demo Days

Showcase of specific XR projects
October 16-17 (Requires sign-up)

Registration at: https://www.tickettailor.com/events/xdn/2454481

The Grand Hotel Sand Fountain

(Augmented Reality | 2025)
Created by Scott Rettberg, Caitlin Fisher and Roderick Coover
Additional development by Julian Pillis and Colin Robinson

AR experience for Android tablets

Platforms used: Adode Aero, Unity, DALL•E 3, Adobe Photoshop, ElevenLabs

The first of the Visitations: The Grand Hotels of Joseph Cornell series, Sand Fountain is a collaborative AR project that extends one of the imaginary universes of Joseph Cornell's collage shadowbox hotel series and the Robert Coover's book of short fictions The Grand Hotels (of Joseph Cornell). The Grand Hotel Sand Fountain is a place of memory and loss. The work takes a kaleidoscopic approach to time, image, and language through the creation of evocative and entangled narratives interweaving past texts and imagined actions. Visitors walk three poetic narratives were individually written and collaboratively crafted. The visuals range from deeply personal ephemera to AI-generated images. The narration plays between human voice and generated speech. Haunted objects come to life through collaborative writing methods, assembling fleeting stories, experimenting with generative AI platforms in the AR production workflow, resulting new storytelling methods.

Bio:

Roderick Coover is a filmmaker, digital artist, and professor of Film and Media Arts at Temple University in Philadelphia. A pioneer of interactive cinema and immersive storytelling, he combines documentary research, experimental film, and digital technologies to explore environmental change, cultural experience, and the possibilities of narrative. His works include *Unknown Territories*, *Toxi•City: A Climate Change Narrative*, and the collaborative virtual reality installation *Hearts and Minds: The Interrogations Project*. His projects have been exhibited internationally, including at the Venice Biennale, SIGGRAPH, and the Bibliothèque nationale de France. He edited *The Digital Imaginary: Literature and Cinema of the Database* and coedited *Switching Codes*. Coover holds a doctorate from the University of Chicago and received Fulbright, Mellon, and Whiting fellowships and awards. He is collaborating with Caitlin Fisher and Scott Rettberg on the *Visitations: The Grand Hotels (of Joseph Cornell)* series of immersive narratives.

Bio

Caitlin Fischer is an award-winning digital storyteller and poet, working mostly in XR. She directs the art+ science Immersive Storytelling Lab and the Augmented Reality Lab at York University in Toronto. At York she is also Chair and a Full Professor in the Department of Film and Media Arts. A co-founder of York's Future Cinema Lab and former Fulbright and Canada Research Chair, Caitlin has funded research projects in the areas of AI storytelling, co-creation between settler and indigenous artists in VR environments and is bringing the power of storytelling to the global health crisis of antimicrobial resistance through a new XR Museum project. She is immediate past President of the Electronic Literature Organization and is also a Prof. II at the University of Bergen, working with the Centre for Digital Narrative.

Bio:

Scott Rettberg is director of the Center for Digital Narrative (CDN), a Norwegian Centre of Research Excellence, and professor of digital culture at the University of Bergen. A writer, artist, and scholar, he explores how computational technologies transform storytelling, authorship, and creative practice. He cofounded the Electronic Literature Organization and served as its first executive director. His book Electronic Literature received the 2019 N. Katherine Hayles Award for Criticism of Electronic Literature. His collaborative works include The Unknown, Implementation, and Hearts and Minds: The Interrogations Project, winner of the 2016 Robert Coover Award. Rettberg leads the Extending Digital Narrative project, investigating emerging narrative forms through artistic experimentation with artificial intelligence, games, and extended reality. He is collaborating with Roderick Coover and Caitlin Fisher on the Visitations: The Grand Hotels (of Joseph Cornell) series of immersive narratives.

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The Grand Hotel Galactic Center

(VR / Work in progress | 2026)
Created by Scott Rettberg, Caitlin Fisher and Roderick Coover
VR development by Colin Robinson

Platforms used: Unity, Marble, ChatGPT Image, Adobe Photoshop, Claude (Code)

The third work in the Visitations: The Grand Hotels (of Joseph Cornell) series, the headset VR experience The Grand Hotel Galactic Center is perhaps the grandest of the grand hotels–at a glance–but after several days in the bubble you realize why the rooms come so cheap. It is a hotel of both wonder and despair. The clouds are on an infinite loop. The stars are all flickering. Glitzy exteriors concealing broken-down infrastructure Like a boarding house that is maintained without care. The exotic floor show almost makes up for it. But you sense that it is the same every night, and the performers are just going through the motions. You wish you could see something beyond the banality, but it just isn't there. You might have loved this when you were a child, but every ounce of your childhood is gone, sapped from you. This is the kind of palliative care you get with the basic insurance. Galactic Center explores text-to-VR environment generation and gaussians splat as components of a Unity development process.

Trigger warning: includes a reference to suicide.

Bio:

Roderick Coover is a filmmaker, digital artist, and professor of Film and Media Arts at Temple University in Philadelphia. A pioneer of interactive cinema and immersive storytelling, he combines documentary research, experimental film, and digital technologies to explore environmental change, cultural experience, and the possibilities of narrative. His works include *Unknown Territories*, *Toxi•City: A Climate Change Narrative*, and the collaborative virtual

reality installation *Hearts and Minds: The Interrogations Project*. His projects have been exhibited internationally, including at the Venice Biennale, SIGGRAPH, and the Bibliothèque nationale de France. He edited *The Digital Imaginary: Literature and Cinema of the Database* and coedited *Switching Codes*. Coover holds a doctorate from the University of Chicago and received Fulbright, Mellon, and Whiting fellowships and awards. He is collaborating with Caitlin Fisher and Scott Rettberg on the *Visitations: The Grand Hotels (of Joseph Cornell)* series of immersive narratives.

Bio

Caitlin Fischer is an award-winning digital storyteller and poet, working mostly in XR. She directs the art+ science Immersive Storytelling Lab and the Augmented Reality Lab at York University in Toronto. At York she is also Chair and a Full Professor in the Department of Film and Media Arts. A co-founder of York's Future Cinema Lab and former Fulbright and Canada Research Chair, Caitlin has funded research projects in the areas of AI storytelling, co-creation between settler and indigenous artists in VR environments and is bringing the power of storytelling to the global health crisis of antimicrobial resistance through a new XR Museum project. She is immediate past President of the Electronic Literature Organization and is also a Prof. II at the University of Bergen, working with the Centre for Digital Narrative.

Bio:

Scott Rettberg is director of the Center for Digital Narrative (CDN), a Norwegian Centre of Research Excellence, and professor of digital culture at the University of Bergen. A writer, artist, and scholar, he explores how computational technologies transform storytelling, authorship, and creative practice. He cofounded the Electronic Literature Organization and served as its first executive director. His book Electronic Literature received the 2019 N. Katherine Hayles Award for Criticism of Electronic Literature. His collaborative works include The Unknown, Implementation, and Hearts and Minds: The Interrogations Project, winner of the 2016 Robert Coover Award. Rettberg leads the Extending Digital Narrative project, investigating emerging narrative forms through artistic experimentation with artificial intelligence, games, and extended reality. He is collaborating with Roderick Coover and Caitlin Fisher on the Visitations: The Grand Hotels (of Joseph Cornell) series of immersive narratives.

Website: https://retts.net/grandhotels/
Contact info: Scott.Rettberg@uib.no

Her Name Was Gisberta

(VR | 2023)
Created by Sérgio Galvão Roxo

Her Name Was Gisberta is a VR/2D documentary that portrays the life and death of Gisberta Salce, a Brazilian Trans woman murdered by 14 young men (12 - 16 years old) in the city of Porto (Portugal) in 2006. Uniting the knowledge provided by Virtual Reality Perspective-Taking

Tasks, this project was created as a tool of education, social intervention and activism against transphobia.

Emperor

(VR | 2023)
Created by Marion Burger and Ilan Cohen

Emperor, an interactive and narrative experience which invites us to travel inside the brain of a father, suffering from aphasia. Alongside his daughter, we journey into the father's mental space – imagined as a hand-drawn, monochrome landscape – as she seeks to learn more about his inner self, now obscured by illness.

Bio:
Marion Burger is a French filmmaker and production designer whose work spans cinema and immersive storytelling. She has worked as a production designer on films including Divines (2016), Gagarine (2020), and Mother and Son (2022). Her directorial debut, EMPEROR (2023), co-created with Ilan J. Cohen, is an interactive virtual reality experience inspired by her father's experience of aphasia. Combining monochromatic, hand-drawn landscapes with poetic and surrealist storytelling, the work explores language, memory, communication, and the emotional bonds between family members.

Bio:
Ilan J. Cohen is a French filmmaker, screenwriter, and director whose practice encompasses cinema, music videos, and immersive storytelling. Since 2008, he has worked as a first assistant director on film productions while developing his own writing and directing projects, including music videos for musicians such as Rone and Gaspar Claus. Together with Marion Burger, he co-wrote and co-directed EMPEROR (2023), an interactive virtual reality experience that explores aphasia through the inner world of a father who has lost the ability to speak. The project combines immersive narrative, animation, and poetic visual design to investigate language, memory, and human connection

Goliath

(VR | 2022)
Created by ANAGRAM

Through mind-bending animation, *GOLIATH: PLAYING WITH REALITY* explores the limits of reality and a true story of so-called 'schizophrenia' and the power of gaming communities. Echo (Tilda Swinton) guides you through the many realities of Goliath, a man who spent years isolated in psychiatric institutions but finds connection in multiplayer games. Combining heartfelt dialogue, mesmerising visuals and symbolic interactions, weave through multiple worlds to uncover Goliath's poignant story.

Bio:

ANAGRAM is an award-winning creative studio specialising in interactive storytelling and immersive experiences. Working at the intersection of documentary, technology, and artistic experimentation, the studio creates thought-provoking works that explore human experiences and social issues through innovative forms of audience engagement. Its productions include *Goliath: Playing with Reality* (2021/2022), an animated virtual reality experience exploring schizophrenia, gaming, and human connection. Directed by Barry Gene Murphy and May Abdalla, narrated by Tilda Swinton, and co-produced with Floréal Films, the project won the Grand Jury Prize for Best VR Work at the 2021 Venice International Film Festival and received numerous international awards and nominations, including an Emmy nomination.

Fiery Sparks of Light

(Augmented Reality | 2021)
Created by Caitlin Fisher

Fiery Sparks of Light is an AR experience that reimagines a collection of poems by four renowned Canadian women poets - Margaret Atwood, Nicole Brossard, Canisia Lubrin and Sarah Tolmie. It was launched as part of an exclusive hybrid (onsite/digital) programme in Germany that celebrates Canada as the Frankfurt Book Fair Guest of Honor 2021.

Using volumetric cinema technology as the foundation, *Fiery Sparks of Light* includes an accompanying printed book that contains QR codes that bring Atwood, Brossard, Lubrin and Tolmie to life as holograms on a mobile device. This enabled Book Fair guests to experience these four poets reading their own original poems, which explore feminist perspectives of patriarchy, gendered objectification, stereotyping and oppression, while further augmented audiovisual after-effects enhance the viewer's experience. This sensory exploration is designed to elicit an emotional response as users set the stage for these fiery written words to spark to life.

Bio

Caitlin Fischer is an award-winning digital storyteller and poet, working mostly in XR. She directs the art+ science Immersive Storytelling Lab and the Augmented Reality Lab at York University in Toronto. At York she is also Chair and a Full Professor in the Department of Film and Media Arts. A co-founder of York's Future Cinema Lab and former Fulbright and Canada Research Chair, Caitlin has funded research projects in the areas of AI storytelling, co-creation between settler and indigenous artists in VR environments and is bringing the power of storytelling to the global health crisis of antimicrobial resistance through a new XR Museum project. She is immediate past President of the Electronic Literature Organization and is also a Prof. II at the University of Bergen, working with the Centre for Digital Narrative.

REALIDAD MITIGADA

(Augmented Reality / Interactive Digital Literature | 2022)
Created by Tina Escaja

Realidad Mitigada (Mitigated Reality) is an AR/Extended Reality App created for the project and hybrid book *Realidad Mitigada*, a book that collects poems and digital "artefacts" by Tina Escaja (aka Alm@ Pérez). Many of Escaja's poems and digital works reflects upon issues of social justice, such as domestic violence (Luna Morada/Black Moon) and informatics control (Bar Codes), which makes this book particularly relevant given its potential subversion of traditional technologies that have served to legitimate oppression, such as the printing press. *Realidad mitigada / Mitigated Reality* is an innovative work created by four professionals in the digital arts. The AR app for the project allows the reader to have an "extended reality" experience that will provide a unique and groundbreaking involvement. The series of stickers located at the end of the book expands the "Virus and the Sea" segment of the book to the community by inviting the reader to place them in random locations, in the way that the QR codes for Escaja's COVID-19 project have already been posted in cities around the world to collect testimonies about our experiences during the pandemic.

Earth Fortunes

Augmented Reality | 2020
Created by Caitlin Fisher

Earth Fortunes is a conceived of as an exploratory journey through some of the ways energy systems affect our lives. If you are excited, worried, or unsure about future energy systems, Earth Fortunes allows you to 'foretell' the planet's future using tarot cards outfitted with augmented reality (AR) visualization informed by the climate science and scientific climate modelling.

When activated as a role playing game, the character of the fortune teller can lay out the tarot deck and then point a smart phone at the centre cards to make holographic visualizations appear. They can then use those augmented reality images to racount and bring to life the story of five different Shared Socioeconomic Pathways (SSPs).

The Augmented Reality visualizations linked to the tarot cards were created using the Global Change Analysis Model (GCAM), developed by the Joint Global Change Research Institute, and a set of long-term scenarios, otherwise known as the Shared Socio-economic Pathways (SSP), to model possible socio-economic and environmental futures.

The graphs and values reported in this kit were developed by consulting with a computer model called GCAM: the Global Change Analysis Model.

Bio

Caitlin Fischer is an award-winning digital storyteller and poet, working mostly in XR. She directs the art+ science Immersive Storytelling Lab and the Augmented Reality Lab at York University in Toronto. At York she is also Chair and a Full Professor in the Department of Film and Media Arts. A co-founder of York's Future Cinema Lab and former Fulbright and Canada Research Chair, Caitlin has funded research projects in the areas of AI storytelling, co-creation between settler and indigenous artists in VR environments and is bringing the power of storytelling to the global health crisis of antimicrobial resistance through a new XR Museum project. She is immediate past

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